he said, had come to ‘a dead stop’. Once again, the DSP raised the bogey of liquidation; it remained to be seen, he said, if the company would be wound up voluntarily or some creditors, ‘of whom there are many’, would take it to court. The company had lost all local sympathy due to its ‘unbusinesslike dealings with local merchants’ some of whom had now switched their custom to BI. Like a Cassandra, he said, the fate of the company would be ‘definitely known … in about a month’. Collector L. Davidson, in forwarding this report, conceded that the company was receiving contributions from outside, if not from within the district, and added cautiously; ‘it is not easy to predict how long they may be able to postpone a final collapse’.[8] This was an oft-repeated prediction that the officials had made right from the establishment of the company.

If the DSP made the above statements based on intelligence received from his sleuths, the collector of Madurai, H.F.W. Gillman made his own inquiries on a private visit to Colombo on casual leave. The accuracy of his assessment of the company’s balance sheet (see the last chapter) is open to question. But other details from his report carry more credibility, especially the list of SSNCo’s ‘pressing claims’ in Colombo.

Ex parte decrees had been issued on 16 February against the *Lawoe* on account of an unpaid bill of Rs 3,215-15-0 for water supplied by the Cargo Boat Despatch Company while Rs 3,080 was due to a Marakayar merchant for provisions. The *Lawoe* had narrowly escaped sale in settlement of these debts. But Rs 6,000 was still owed to the harbour. The Marakayar merchant had got a further decree from another court for Rs 3,000 against the *Gallia*, also for unpaid provisions. Though an order had been issued for appraisal and sale, the Madurai collector was sure that the bills would be settled before that. SSNCo’s Colombo Agent too was getting impatient, as he awaited the settlement of his Rs 20,000 while the other claims were being cleared.

Gillman’s report confirmed that both steamers, in desperate need of repair, were moored at Colombo with only a caretaker. From a conversation with the surveyor of the *Gallia*, Gillman gathered that the French engines were ‘just like a toy shop’—whatever that meant—and were beyond the